THE BOOK'S OPENING · ORIENTATION · UNIT 2 IN THE COURSE

Conclusion

con·clu·sion (noun) the ending of something

"Are you watching closely?"

— **Alfred Borden, The Prestige**

Most books don't begin with the ending - especially history ones. Most movies don't either. Yet, the great ones begin where you least expect only to untangle everything as the story unfolds.

Are you intrigued?

Are you watching closely?

You cracked open a book with the title The Concise History of Retirement and are probably expecting a book that reads chronologically. After all, that is how we normally read history. Past to present. Then to now. What happened at a certain date and time.

That makes perfect sense! I took a lot of history classes too! We know what to expect when we see a history text book. Events, people and places in a sequential order. 1492 to 1776 to 1941.

There is so much that makes up "history." There are major figures and regular people. There are key events and the ordinary. There are often two sides, winners and losers and "History is written by the victors" — often attributed to Winston Churchill and something we can probably intuit makes sense and leaves the history we have been told wanting.

We grow up learning history as a series of facts. We learn about different empires over time. We learn about ancient civilizations. We learn about the technological advancements that sprang up. Cave paintings, the pyramids, the printing press, the steam engine, the light bulb. The tests we have to pass in school asks, "what happened on what date." We fill in the bubble indicating the correct answer on our scantron paper... Oh no! I just aged myself and may have outed you. I am so sorry despite fond memories of a personal history that includes a beloved scantron and maybe an overhead projector.

Yet, history is so much more than facts. It is consequential in that all that has happened before has influenced where we are today and where we are headed. And that brings us back to Churchill when he said in 1948, "Those that fail to learn from history are doomed to repeat it."

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Why a Concise History of Retirement?

I am glad you asked and to answer that I will give you three concise answers. One is personal. One is practical. The final one is problematic.

First the personal. No one asked me to write this book but I know you were demanding this type of work be done! This is the conclusion after all and you end this book by being so glad you picked it up. “Life changing!” you exclaim. For me, this began as part of my first book The Future Poor: How families and communities can survive the looming retirement crisis. I had a short chapter in there that was the seed of what you now hold. I felt I was at the start of seeing something important with the history of retirement. I had the scaffolding but that was about all. It was enough to make the points I needed for that book but I knew there was much more to do. The more I worked with clients and discussed the trajectory of retirement the more the history became illuminated. Echoes of the past were showing up everywhere from hundred year old rules, to tax laws of previous generations, to ideological shifts and financial products created half a century ago. Each of these threads was woven together into this thing we now call retirement. I wanted to understand it deeply and here at the end you do too!

I mentioned the second reason for a concise history of retirement being my practical side. I like short books rather than massive treatments of things. History is a massive thing to unpack which is why each of the characters in our story about retirement have multiple biographies and each of the events mentioned here fill volumes of encyclopedias. I wanted to shrink that down and hit the high points and illustrate the arc of history that ends here with you and your moment in the story. It is important for you to see where you are now and step forward into what is next.

This book is also concise because retirement as a thing, as an idea, as something people do is relatively new. The history of retirement is concise and so the book should be too! Most are surprised to realize we are only about 130 years in on this idea. That may seem like a long time for you and me but in the scope of human history, that is a blip. As something new in the course of human history, it needs to be understood.

And now the problematic reason for this book and a call back to my first book. It’s in the title and you’ve already seen the end. Retirement, which I broadly define as exiting work at 65 and living your remaining years off your money, is a catastrophe. My original thesis of The Future Poor is that 9 out of 10 people under age 50 (sub-50) and making less than $150,000/year (sub-150) are going to be living at or below poverty level in their senior years. That has not changed. That is not good. That is a catastrophe. The rest of this book is why.

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When we understand the history and see the different seeds of ideas that gave us this catastrophic ending we can join with those that already see, undo the tangled knot and build something better. You get it and why you are passing this book along to everyone you know.

Your Advice for New Readers

Here at the end you have a better sense of how this book is to be read. Like we do when we tell a friend about a TV show, a movie or our favorite restaurant - we want to set them up for an enjoyable experience. Perhaps we offer some tips or insider information about things we have come to learn from experience. But we also know the truth of what C.S. Lewis said about expectations being everything. We can't oversell the movie and create disappointment. We've all been told something is the best only to encounter it and walk away feeling "meh" about it. That is why we do the balancing act of informing and not giving away the plot.

"The parking is terrible so park around the corner. And get there early before it gets packed."

"Do you mind the sight of blood on screen? You do? Ok. Then you probably shouldn't watch The Pitt."

"You know it starts off slow but if you make it to episode 3 or past the first 10 minutes it really picks up pace."

"Make sure to ask what they are serving that is not on the menu."

These are the things we naturally do and so here is what I imagine you are telling others about how to read this particular book and what to pay attention to. You love this book and cannot wait to share it with friends, family and co-workers but you want them to walk away with the same experience. I cannot blame you for that! So here is what you tell people as you pass this along.

I ran into M. Night Shyamalan story. If you tell your friend Bruce Willis is dead the whole time in the Sixth Sense the movie doesn't have the magic it is supposed to carry. In a way I have told you this fact but you aren't familiar enough with the details for it to set in. Retirement is Dead and has been the whole time might be revealed but you haven't seen the detail of it being cold and seeing your breath when Willis is around. But watching it over again you will see all the details you missed along the way.

"C's"

As you read this book you will encounter a couple themes that run throughout. One is that there are a lot of "C's." Just look at the table of contents! Each chapter starts with a "C." They show up in various places. Because I told you this you will see them everywhere as you read. Alliteration is a powerful device and they show up throughout.

The purpose of this book is to invite you in to paying attention. You will now see more “c’s” than I ever intended. It is subconscious - the way you notice the car you drive.

“Seeds. Yes seeeeds. (emphasis on the D) Not C’s“

What you’ll come to find out is retirement as we know it is a collection of ideas that began as seeds that grew together and grew into bigger ideas. It is not one single seed that gave rise to what we now think of as retirement — “exit work at age 65 and live off your money.” There is a lot of range in that simplistic definition but that is what most of us think that term means. Eventually, several seeds all grew into developed ideas that form the foundation for our current concept of retirement. Seeing them over time is really interesting.

“Conflation”

There you go — a “C” right off the bat. I told you. Throughout this book there is a lot of work done to untangle two ideas that have become conflated. Conflation is the merging of two ideas into one. Right here, I am going to give you some of the secrets to the remainder of what you are about to read.

The first idea is the humanitarian one that asks how do we care for people as they age.

The second is the structural one that asks what systems and structures do we put in place to make the first idea a reality.

What we have today is a conflation of these two that requires us to turn to 2003 and the band Hoobastank … “and the reason is You.”

I truly am sorry for the reference and that this song will now be stuck in your head for a couple weeks.

“I’m not a perfect person…”

Alright, Stop!

If you said in your mind “collaborate and listen” this book is for you. But unfortunately this is a problem Vanilla Ice can’t solve. If your mind is now playing late 90’s early 2000’s hits just let it. Enjoy the moment.

Play “Closing Time” or “Higher” or go all in on our universal love of Nickelback and play “How you remind me” none of us want to admit it but when that song comes on….

No matter what early 2000’s hit you gravitate to, and I respect them all, the reality remains - a lot has happened since then.

“The Ending”

The ending is already revealed. And Linkin Park might have been wrong when they said “in the end it doesn’t even matter.”

You tried so hard and you got so far.

Maybe they were right.

You do not even need to buy the previous book The Future Poor to know the ending. But you really should, that one is great too! The ending is Catastrophe. That is on the cover of this book!

Are you watching closely?

Keep that question in your mind at all times and it will help you see the reveal, to see the ending. I will reveal everything as we go.

I just said it is in the title of this book where this leads to… Catastrophe.

“Christopher”

Yup — another “C.”

One of the great things about this book are movie references as they are able to illustrate realities we encounter in our daily life in ways words fail. Narrative has always been the language to capture the deeper things of life. It used to be books and evolved into cinematic story telling. They also connect to popular culture and stories we all can resonate with. This is often more powerful than anything I could do with charts, graphs or logic. Story and narrative connect much deeper than basic prose cannot.

So who is the greatest of these story tellers?

George Lucas, of course. He gave us Star Wars — the original trilogy. The best mythological story and movies ever made.

But that isn’t Christopher.

You are correct (another c) — I am talking about Christopher Nolan and the intrigue with his work since Memento. Memento was the first of Nolan’s movies that didn’t follow a traditional chronological approach. This movie runs backwards in order to understand the ending. Or the beginning. Or the ending. I don’t know but I know it works.

Then there is his movie Inception. Dreams within dreams that made people question reality in ways not felt since The Matrix. More about this later.

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But that was only the start. Does anyone understand Tenet? A movie that I think is running forward and backward at the same time?! Who knows?!

This book pays homage to Nolan in my own way and began with the question, “Are you watching closely?”

Some of us know that from Nolan’s movie The Prestige which is actually an adaptation of a book by the same name written by another “C” — Christopher Priest. If you haven’t seen it yet you need to check it out. But that question becomes a guiding question as you journey through this history and continues to sit in your mind as you see how the story unfolds.

So, What Else Do I Need to Know About This Book?

This is the question your friend has just asked you as you hand this copy over to them while discussing it over coffee. They asked as they took it, opened it up and casually flipped through the pages as if to get a glance at what wisdom might be contained within these pages the way we all do when handed a book.

You start to respond in the normal way by saying, “It starts in the time before…” BUT you catch yourself mid-sentence. That type of retelling might not do this particular book justice. You pause for a second to think.

“Have you ever seen the movie Inception?” you ask.

“Yeah, that’s the weird one about dreams within dreams. Was that one by Christopher Nolan?” They are able to jump right to Nolan and the references this book makes and because of what you just talked about — a little inception of your own and you know their mind is set up well for what you are about to share.

“That’s the one!”

“That was a crazy movie. Great cast.”

“Oh man, yeah. Leo. Michael Caine.”

“Wasn’t Tom Hardy in that?”

“He was. So was Cillian Murphy.” You don’t want to digress too much further into that great cast so you ask, “You know that feeling of falling you get while dreaming?”

Your friend immediately responds, “That is the worst! Your body flinches and you wake up like what in the world was that?!”

“Why does it always feel so real?” you reply in agreement. “So, in the movie one of the things I remember most is that they use that feeling of falling to wake the dreamer from the dream.”

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“I remember that. Doesn’t Leo fall into a bath tub? Am I remembering that right?”

“Ha! At the beginning. The first dream we see. What they call it throughout the movie is ‘The Kick’ — the feeling of falling that the body naturally and involuntarily responds to. Like when the body responds to the dream of falling. ‘The Kick’ is the thing that wakes people from a dream…”

This book is ‘The Kick.’